

This move will not only solidify India's presence in the global digital payments space, but it will also open the gates for the country to take the lead in transforming the way in which we make cross-border payments.

ISRO – The most cost-effective space agency in the world

Indian Space Research Organisation's achievements are all to write home about. From stellar accomplishments



like making India the first nation to land on the South Pole of the Moon to contributing to international projects that could redefine our understanding of space, the list is endless. However, in addition to all this, ISRO has emerged as one of the most cost-effective agencies in the world. Again, let's make the numbers do the talking –

India's Mars orbiter mission, dubbed the Mangalyaan, is a prime example of how ISRO can achieve what other agencies often dream of at a fraction of the cost. You may have come across this statistic quite often on the internet, but to set the context here, I am mentioning it again. The total cost of the Mangalyaan mission for ISRO was approximately \$73 million. On the contrary, a movie about Matt Damon's character's experience on Mars, *The Martian*, was made in 2015, and it was produced at a cost of \$108 million. That is a \$25 million difference in cost right there! And, if that is not enough, the time between the start of ISRO's Mangalyaan project and the launch was just 18 months.

No one can imagine a scenario where countries that are developing their space program are looking for a place to make their ideas a reality. Where would they go? To a country which is brimming with some of the brilliant scientific brains across the globe and can execute the incoming country's visions at a cheaper cost. Right? Well, that place is going to be India.

With more and more countries turning their eyes towards India as ISRO sets unprecedented milestones in a very cost-effective manner, we will soon see India's rise to becoming the space science and technology factory of the world. Fingers crossed, and hopes to the moon!

Smartwatches – Indians are adapting to emerging technologies

If you have been out and about in the last couple of years, especially after the COVID-19 pandemic, or have observed market trends, you would have seen a lot of people rocking smartwatches on their wrists. If not that, the very fact that there are numerous options available on e-commerce platforms and services like Blinkit and Swiggy Instamart are already selling smartwatches on their stores is indicative that Indians are looking at smartwatches now more than ever before.

This increased demand is also reflected in the recent statistics published by the research agency Counterpoint. Their report, published on June 6,

showed that India has come to be at the top of the smartwatch markets across the globe in Q1 2024. This is also corroborated by the insights published by IDC, which suggests that the smartwatch shipments in the country clocking in at 9.6 million. India's rise becomes even more astonishing, as this is the first time the growth trajectory flattened for the first time in two years. Yet, we maintain the crown of being one of the biggest smartwatch markets in the world!

India is a country where price-conscious consumers are often slow to adopt technology trends. But this stellar demand for smartwatches, complimented by the presence of some excellent offerings introduced by home-grown brands, showcases a trend that Indian consumers are open to new technologies. To add a personal anecdote here, during the launch event of the OnePlus Open, which was also held in India late last year, there was a line of at least 100-150 people to pre-book the phone. Mind you, this is a phone priced north of 150K INR. This was OnePlus' first foldable phone. This shows that Indians are more open than ever to adopting new technologies.

What is the road ahead?

Well, growth trajectories across different sectors of science and technology have set the tone for India's growing prominence on the global stage. There is enough data hinting at this rise. You read some here, and a simple search will showcase that India's growth chart is on an upward trajectory. What we as citizens need to do is to support the drivers of this growth as much as we can. There will be roadblocks along the way, but we need to take charge and pave the way to foster innovation and growth in India and give Indian researchers and developers, and passionate inventors, the ecosystem that they need and deserve.

If you are someone who is developing something in the world of science and technology or know someone else who is, write to me at satvik@digit.in, I would love to hear from you and explore their journey. 

